

What else to watch: *M* (1931, pp.46–47) ■ *Build My Gallows High* (1947, p.332) ■ *Angel Face* (1952) ■ *Les Diaboliques* (1955) ■ *Touch of Evil* (1958, p.333) ■ *Cape Fear* (1962)



her two children. Willa is to be the next hapless victim of his creepy yet all too smooth preacher act.

Light and shadow

One of the most notable aspects of *The Night of the Hunter* is how powerfully it communicates significance in ways other than

dialogue. For instance, encroaching threat is conveyed by the overtly styled framing of the children's hiding place in a barn, juxtaposed with Powell on the distant horizon, or by the way shadows overwhelm a bedroom, leaving what little light remains to create the effect of an altar as Powell murders Willa. The

Light and shade are used to frame key images. As Powell stands over Willa, knife in hand, her bedroom is converted by the shadows into a perverted church.

image of a corrupted altar in a church mirrors Powell's own status as a false prophet, an amoral man who uses the word of God to serve his own nefarious purposes.

The use of high-contrast black-and-white photography also helps to highlight the contrast between good and evil in the movie. »

“‘She’ll **not be back**. I reckon I’m safe in promising you that.’”

Harry Powell / The Night of the Hunter